

Mizoram needs 10,000 metric tonne of rice every month

Then comes a warning from the lofty heights of MacDonald Hill which is meant for the power brokers thousands of miles away in Delhi. "If the government of India fails this time, it would give rise to a second insurgency. Even now, 90 per cent of the Mizos want an independent nation."

Zoramthanga's statement is neither empty rhetoric nor an empty threat. In Mizoram there is a silent but strong faith in the idea of "Zoram", a separate geographical entity, a new nation that includes Mizoram, parts of Manipur, Tripura and Assam, and even parts of Bangladesh and Burma, which are chiefly occupied by the group of tribes generically known as Mizo and their sister tribes. A paper written by Paul Chonzik, a college lecturer in Aizawl, states that the land of Zoram might never be a reality, but local customs and social practices still bind the region strongly together through social ties.

Many houses in Aizawl have a map of Zoram on the walls. According to some reports, certain areas of northern Mizoram and the villages around the Vangai Range in Manipur, which is also experiencing the *mautam*, want to actually declare independence from the Indian state.

Along the National Highway 150—which is supposed to connect Aizawl with Imphal, the capital of Manipur—lie some of the areas which are hardest hit by the famine, where a private outfit called the MAUTAM (Mautam Affected areas Upliftment for Tripura, Assam and Manipur) Task Force will be delivering supplies of rice.

The NH-150 is no smooth stretch of tarmac, at best a dirt track with knee-deep mud that runs for miles. The bridge connecting the two states was washed away by floods six years ago, and all that is left is a precarious-looking bridge made of bamboo hanging

high over the Barak river. The man behind the MAUTAM Task Force, John L. Pudaite, whose father was a mediator between the MNF and the government before the signing of the peace accord in 1986, says that Mizoram, with its roads, electricity, and a proactive government, is still better off compared

to the 34-year-old RJD MLA and student leader, Ngursanglur Sanate. Other than an excuse for a road, the only way to travel in these parts is by boat along the Barak river that overlooks the insurgent-occupied Vangai range.

In Manipur, the Churachandpur and Tamenglang districts are the hardest hit by the *mautam*. Some areas of Churachandpur, like Sartuinek village in the hills, are conventionally inaccessible by road. Getting there includes a two-day-long boat ride and a day-long trek. The residents of the village, which has about 87 families, walk five hours to and fro for a sackful of rice provided by the MAUTAM Task Force. That is the only food they have received for the entire year. "We have not harvested even a tin of rice this year," says a farmer, who then thinks nothing of offering milk to visitors as a sign of hospitality.

Sanate says that there is a backlog of about 64,600 quintals of rice to be given to the Churachandpur district. The Manipur government has not yet handed out even a kilo. Some of it, he fears, has been siphoned off by insurgent outfits. Rice meant for the famine-struck villages, easily recognisable by their wrapping, can now be found on sale in the bazaars in Silchar and Agartala. Victims of a peculiar natural scourge and, equally, of a remote central administration, the famine-hit villagers of Mizoram and Manipur offer outsiders their own food almost by reflex.

At the height of the bamboo famine, the brutality of nature has tried to overwhelm the beauty of Mizoram's landscape. After 48 years, once again the *mautam* has devastated rice fields, ravaged households and shown up Delhi's detachment. But once again it has failed to destroy the region's common humanity. ■

OF MICE AND MEN



FRUSTRATED: Facing a food shortage in his state, Mizoram Chief Minister Zoramthanga resents the Centre's reluctance to distribute adequate rice



THE PIED PIPER OF AIZAWL: C. Rokhuma, at his laboratory shed. He had warned the Mizoram government as early as 1998 to prepare for the rise of the rodents. 20,000 rat tails are now burnt every week

to other neighbouring states.

At Tipaimukh, where Mizoram and Manipur meet, the local MLA says that a bag of rice takes three days to reach a village in Manipur, and even then, most of it already is taken away as cuts by several insurgent groups. "I try my best to convince the state government of the condition in these parts," says